# THE COVENANT WAR

**DOCUMENT:** Master Script v6 - Complete Prologue

**STATUS:** Updated 24 October 2026

## Prologue P1: The Attic

*(The protagonist awakens on a cot under bare timber rafters. Pale morning light filters through a frost-cracked shutter. On the washbasin opposite the bed sits an oval mirror veiled in cold grey condensation.)*

**[NARRATOR - MORROWEN] (V.O.)**

"Every soul in my book starts with a debt. Most spend a lifetime paying interest on a life they never asked for, trying to balance an account that was written before they were born."

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[OBJECTIVE: Walk to the washbasin (LS/WASD).]
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*(The protagonist steps up to the mirror and presses E/X to inspect their reflection.)*

**INTERACTIVE REFLECTION HUB**

*(The protagonist wipes the frost from the glass with a bare palm, studying their reflection. The ash-grey mark on their collarbone resembles a broken seal.)*

**Q0 (REQUIRED): "What's my name again?"**

[CHARACTER NAME ENTRY] A name-entry screen opens. Player types and confirms their name; save it as [PLAYER_NAME] for future dialogue and UI before advancing.

[INNER VOICE] "That's right. [PLAYER_NAME]. Bram still calls me Sprout."

**Q1: "Why do I hide this mark under my collar?"**

[INNER VOICE] "Because you are unbound. The gods hold no mortgage on your soul, and Ironvault has no receipt for your birth. In a world where every king and kingdom is pledged to a patron, a person who owes nothing is a rarity... and a threat to Aurex Morne's bank."

**Q2: "How long have I lived under Bram's roof?"**

[INNER VOICE] "Twenty years. Ever since an old man walked out of a crater in the Shardlands carrying a baby tucked inside his heavy coat. He bought this inn with unexplained gold, gave you a bed, and taught you to keep your head down."

**Option 3: Step away from the glass. (Progresses Scene after name confirmation.)**

**[BRAM] (CALLING UP THROUGH THE FLOORBOARDS)**

"You coming down, Sprout? The draft blew out the pilot lamp, the porridge is getting cold, and Ironvault's bailiffs don't wait for the sun to clear the pass."

## Prologue P1: The Taproom

*(The camera tracks behind the protagonist descending the creaking stairs into the taproom. Bram stands behind the counter, rubbing a rag over an oak surface that doesn't need cleaning.)*

**[BRAM]**

> "Left the shutter unlatched again. Cold air costs firewood, wood costs coin, and coin is the one thing nobody in Ashford has enough of today. Eat something first. I'm not having you walking down to the green on an empty stomach."

**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: BRAM HOLLOWAY**

**Q1: "Ironvault's bailiffs are on the road early today."**
**[BRAM]** "They're always early when a note falls due. Caldus Morne doesn't let his clerks sleep when there's interest compounding in the valley. They've cleared every roof in Ashford except this one."
↳ **Sub-Node: "Is Morne really as dangerous as people say?"**
**[BRAM]** "Morne doesn't raise a sword. He takes off his reading glasses, looks at your ledger page, and gives you a price that sounds completely fair until you realize it costs you everything you own three years down the line."

**Q2: "Is Tam Hayes going to lose the mill tonight?"**
**[BRAM]** "Tam's down there right now counting flour sacks he hasn't even ground yet. Poor bastard can't read the legal script on the letter in his own pocket, and he's too proud to ask Nell to look at it. Go down to the mill first before you head to the green."

**Q3: "Why is this inn the only roof Ironvault doesn't own?"**
**[BRAM]** "Because I paid Aurex Morne in full thirty years back. Four thousand gold crowns, signed and sealed on a single page before his son Caldus took the desk. Gold I bled for. Some debts you pay off in coin, Sprout. Some you carry around in your ribs until your knees give out."

**Option 4: "I'm ready for the festival prep." (Progress)**
**[BRAM]** "Eat every crumb. Then grab the lantern crate from the corner and take it down to the green."

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[OBJECTIVE: Take the lantern crate and proceed to the village green.]
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## Prologue P1: The Mill (Tam Hayes)

*(The protagonist approaches the mill. Tam stands by the heavy wooden waterwheel, running flour-dusted fingers over a thick parchment letter with a dark red wax seal. He rubs the back of his neck, staring helplessly at the ink.)*

**[TAM]**

> "Ah, Sprout. Mind the flour dust on your boots—the draft's blowing hard through the timber seams today. I was just... checking the alignment on the lower stone. Making sure we get a fine grind for the festival loaves before the sun drops."

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[OBJECTIVE: Speak to Tam Hayes at the mill entrance.]
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**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: TAM HAYES**

**Q1: [Notice the letter] "Is that a notice from Ironvault, Tam?"**
**[TAM]** "Aye. Handed it to me without a word. You know how it is for me with the ink, Sprout. Can you... tell me what the House has written down under my name?"
**[PROTAGONIST]** "It's a demand of foreclosure, Tam. It says the advance for the seed-barley falls due at midnight tonight. If four hundred crowns aren't paid in full, the millwheel and water rights revert to Ironvault."
**[TAM]** "Four hundred crowns? I took seventy crowns to buy seed. How in the Seven Courts does seventy crowns turn into four hundred in three winters?"

**↳ Sub-Node: "Why haven't you asked Nell to help you read this?"**
**[TAM]** "Nell's carried enough weight in this valley since the night the sky tore open twenty years back. If she knows the mill is gone at midnight, she won't dance on the green tonight. I just want her to have one warm evening before the bailiffs come."

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**Q2: "How is the harvest coming along this year?"**
**[TAM]** "The stream’s been running cold and dark ever since the Sigilfall up in the Shardlands two weeks back. Waterwheel grinds slow when the river magic goes sour."

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**Option 3: "I won't say a word to Nell until the festival ends." (Progress)**
**[TAM]** "Thank you, Sprout. You're a good lad. Go on up to the green—Corin’s been strutting around the lantern pole for an hour."

## Prologue P1: The Village Green (Tilly & Nell)

*(The protagonist steps onto the bustling green. Villagers are stringing paper lanterns between the timber eaves. Near the well, seven-year-old Tilly is staring sadly at a flat, grey Tier I Spark card in her hands. On a bench nearby sits Nell Hayes.)*

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[OBJECTIVE: Speak to Tilly and Nell on the green.]
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**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: TILLY & NELL**

**Q1: [Speak to Tilly] "Is your moth card not working, Tilly?"**
**[TILLY]** "It won't wake up. Father bought it from a merchant last winter, but the wings just stay flat. Even Tam couldn't summon it, and he calls down a River Hound every morning!"
*(The protagonist kneels and gently touches the edge of the card. Instantly, the grey crystal surface flares with warm amber light. A spectral Lantern Moth flutters up from the card, circling Tilly's head.)*

**[TILLY]** "It flew! Why does it only fly for you?"
**[INNER VOICE]** "You don't know. Anyone in Ashford can summon a basic Totem, but the magic in this valley has always bent toward you without you even asking. A quiet, terrifying habit you've learned to hide."

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**Q2: [Speak to Nell] "Are you waiting for the lantern lighting, Nell?"**
**[NELL]** "I'm waiting for Tam to come up from the mill. He thinks I don't know about the bank's letter. A man's pride is a heavy thing to carry on festival night."
**↳ Sub-Node: "How long have you and Tam lived in Ashford?"**
**[NELL]** "Long enough to remember the night Bram walked out of the Shardlands with you tucked inside his coat. The sky was burning white, and he paid for the inn with gold that smelled of ash. I've never asked him where he found you."

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**Option 3: Step away from the well. (Progress)**

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[OBJECTIVE: Approach Corin by the Great Lantern pole.]
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## Prologue P1: The Lantern Pole (Corin & Bram)

*(Corin is twirling a brass-bound dueling card between his knuckles with flashy speed. He wears a crisp, new wool coat with iron-plated buttons.)*

**[CORIN]**

> "Well, look who finally came down! I was starting to think Bram locked you in the attic so you wouldn't embarrass yourself in front of everyone during the Lantern Duel."

**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: CORIN**

**Q1: "What's that letter tucked into your coat?"**
**[CORIN]** "My ticket out of this mud-hole! A clerkship offer from the Ironvault Notary Guild. I put your name down for an apprenticeship too."
**↳ Sub-Node: "What exactly does an Ironvault Notary do?"**
**[CORIN]** "They calculate the interest on the world, Sprout. They sit in warm rooms while the rest of Veyl freezes, deciding whose fields get watered and whose roofs get taken. It's better to hold the pen than the plough."

**Q2: "You really think you can just walk away from Ashford tonight?"**
**[CORIN]** "The Turning year starts at midnight. Every Seat in Veyl is up for grabs! I'm not staying in a village dying on credit."

**Option 3: "Enough talking. Let's settle the Lantern Duel." (Progress)**
**[PROTAGONIST]** "I would, but I don't have a deck."

*(A heavy hand lands on the protagonist's shoulder. Bram steps into the lantern light, pulling a worn leather deck-box from his coat.)*

**[BRAM]**

> "You do now. Remember what I taught you in the cellar. Draw your Essence, set your Ward, and don't let him distract you."

| Encounter | Opponent | Special Rule |
|---|---|---|
| The Lantern Duel (Tutorial) | Corin | **Showboat:** Corin plays flashy, sub-optimal moves to impress the crowd. |

## Prologue P2: The Midnight Sigilfall

*(The Lantern Duel ends with a cheer from the village. Corin laughs, catching his breath and brushing off his new coat.)*

**[CORIN]**

> "Alright, I yield! You win this year, Sprout. I'll be over by the merchant carts if anyone wants a signed card before I leave for the city!"

*(Corin wades away into the bustling crowd. Hours pass. The festival reaches its joyous peak as midnight approaches. Cinematic: The Great Lantern burns with a rich, golden flame. Little Tilly steps back, her face glowing. Then, the wind simply stops. Every lantern freezes mid-air. The village goes dead silent.)*

*(With a deafening, glass-shattering crack, the sky tears open. A violent, blindingly pure white light bleeds down from the Empyrean, turning the midnight green as stark and pale as bone. The earth bucks violently. The shockwave shatters the merchant carts lining the green.)*

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[OBJECTIVE: The ground is buckling. Find Corin.]
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*(Screams finally break the silence. Through the blinding dust and falling debris, you see Corin on the ground, his new coat torn. A massive, iron-banded wagon wheel has him pinned into the mud.)*

**[CORIN]**

> "Sprout! My leg—it's caught on the axle! I can't shift it, it's crushing the bone!"

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[OBJECTIVE: Mash (E/X) repeatedly to heave the cart upward, then press (F/Square) at the precise moment to pull Corin clear.]
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*(You throw your weight against the splintered oak. A tension meter fills as you heave the wood upward, your muscles burning. You drag Corin free just as the sky unleashes a second, blinding pulse.)*

## Prologue P3: The Awakening (Part 1)

*(A single streak of white light separates from the tear above. It plummets directly toward you. Time slows. The light crashes silently into your open palm. It feels impossibly heavy. A pristine, blank white card rests in your hand.)*

*(An instant later, a searing agony erupts beneath your collarbone. The ash-grey broken seal you've hidden your whole life blazes with white fire. Bram shoves his way through the screaming crowd. His face is pale with terror. He throws his heavy wool coat over you.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Close your fist. Don't look at it. Hide it. Now."

*(You shove the card deep into your coat. But the moment the card is concealed, an overwhelming surge of magical pressure rushes through your veins. Your vision swims. You collapse into the mud, everything going black.)*

*(You open your eyes. The familiar wooden beams of the inn's attic are above you. The sun hasn't quite risen yet. Bram is sitting on a stool beside the cot, his face haggard, gripping a damp cloth.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Thank the Courts. You gave me quite a scare out there, Sprout."

*(He leans forward, his voice dropping into a heavy, unfamiliar severity.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Listen to me carefully. I wanted to break this to you slowly, but the turning of the Age just tore up that timeline. I'm not who you think I am, and you aren't who you think you are. Everything I've done has been to protect you. To protect what you are... and what you're going to become."

#### INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: THE BETRAYAL

**Q1: "Protect me from what? Bram, you aren't making any sense."**
**[PROTAGONIST]**
*(You stare at him, the ringing in your ears slowly fading as you try to piece his disjointed words together.)*

"Protect me from what? What do you mean you aren't who I think you are? Bram, you're not making any sense. And last night... the sky tore open. I remember the cart, and then that light... what happened to me out there? What was that card?"

## Prologue P3: The Awakening (Part 2)

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[LORE RULE: Bram is deeply reluctant to reveal his past. He only tells the protagonist what is strictly necessary for survival, fearing his history will unfairly influence their choices. The full truth of his age and former master will come much later from other gods and quests.]
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**[BRAM]**

"The inn was a lie. My name is a lie. But keeping you safe... that was the truest thing I've ever done. I can't tell you everything yet. I've seen too many kingdoms burn because of the powers I used to serve. I just wanted to stop. I wanted you to just be a boy."

*(He looks down at his scarred hands.)*

**[BRAM]**

"I kept you away from magic because magic *wants* you. I knew channeling Essence would wake you up and light a beacon for every god in Veyl. But the dreams started again. Visions from an old master I haven't heard from in a very long time. I was going to train you slowly, but that card falling forced my hand."

**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: THE ARTIFACT**

**Q2: "What exactly did I catch out there? What is that card?"**
**[BRAM]** "The most dangerous thing in Veyl. A blank space at the bottom of the Covenant. The Last Seal. The gods didn't create this world, they borrowed it—and the Covenant is the loan agreement. Whoever holds the two halves of that seal decides who owns the world."

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**Option 3: "But my chest was on fire. I thought it was going to kill me." (Progress)**
**[BRAM]** "I thought so too. The resonance should have stopped a mortal heart. Tell me, how do you feel now? Is the mark burning?"
**[PROTAGONIST]** "No... I feel fine. Actually... I feel better than I ever have."
*(You look at your hands. The exhaustion is gone. A strange vitality courses through your veins. The card unlocked something dormant inside you.)*

**[BRAM]** "I was afraid of that. The seal isn't just a piece of paper, Sprout. It's a lock. And finding its other half just turned the key."

*(Suddenly, the frantic ringing of the chapel bell cuts through the cold morning air.)*

**[VILLAGERS OUTSIDE]**

"Look at the mist! A Herald! A Herald is approaching!"

**[BRAM]**

"We're out of time. Keep your head down, and whatever happens out there, do not draw your deck."

## Prologue P3: Dawn & The Pale Herald

*(Dawn breaks. The paper lanterns litter the frost-covered grass like dead moths. The villagers stand in a wide, terrified ring around the center of the green. The temperature drops sharply. There is no sound of arrival. It is simply suddenly there, hovering inches above the crushed grass: a towering, shifting mass of grey burial cloth and rusted iron chains. The Pale Herald.)*

**[THE PALE HERALD] (VOICED)**

> "The Age is turned. The Turning year begins. I am the witness. I record the current holders of the seven Dominion Seats, subject to open challenge. Let the blood of the contenders be counted."

*(It begins to list the current Champions. Suddenly, a suffocating heat rises in your chest. The Last Seal in your coat hums with a violent Resonance. The mark on your collarbone blazes bright white. The Pale Herald stops speaking mid-sentence. It pauses in absolute silence. The featureless grey hood snaps directly down to lock onto you. Its grinding voice stutters, as if the ancient laws of Veyl are rewriting themselves in real-time.)*

**[THE PALE HERALD] (VOICED)**

> "The Covenant updates. An eighth Seat is forged. The holder of the Last Seal claims this position. Unmarked by any god, until challenged and broken... they are witnessed. I name the Unsworn."

*(The Herald dissolves into a thick grey mist. The silence on the green is agonizing. Tam Hayes looks at the ground. Nell quietly pulls Tilly away. They are stepping away from you for pure, primal survival. Bram steps firmly into the empty space between you and the village.)*

**INTERACTIVE DIALOGUE HUB: BRAM HOLLOWAY (DAWN)**

**Q1: "What was that thing, Bram?"**
**[BRAM]** "The Covenant's shadow. The Pale Herald. It's the thing the gods send to enforce the rules they wrote for themselves. It doesn't judge, and it doesn't fight. It just records who dies, who owes what, and who holds a Champion's mark."

**Q2: "Why are they looking at me like that?"**
**[BRAM]** "Because a Champion's mark brings duels, armies, and gods to your doorstep. And Ashford doesn't even have a wall. They've kept you a secret for twenty years. That silence just ended."

**Option 3: "We can't stay here. I'm putting everyone in danger." (Progress)**
**[BRAM]** "No. We can't. Come back inside. We have to pack."

## Prologue P4: The Ashford Reckoning

*(That night. The village is eerily quiet. Hoofbeats shatter the silence. Huntmaster Sabine Krell rides into the center of the green on a heavy warhorse, flanked by Ironvault bailiffs bearing torches. She wears the immaculate grey coat of the House. She does not shout; her voice is perfectly measured and polite.)*

**[HUNTMASTER KRELL]**

> "Good evening. I hold the foreclosure notes for twenty-two properties in this valley. By the authority of Caldus Morne and the House of Ironvault, the terms are as follows. Every roof but the inn's is forfeit tonight. Alternatively, you may surrender one card—the white one—and the notes are burned. I will wait five minutes."

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[LORE RULE: The Ashford Pact. The villagers have always known the protagonist was a magical foundling pulled from the Shardlands. Over the years, they formed an unspoken pact to protect the child from the outside world. This collective loyalty is why no one points them out to Ironvault, and why Tam Hayes sacrifices himself.]
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*(Nobody speaks. The silence stretches, heavy and terrified. Then, Tam Hayes steps forward. He places himself deliberately between Krell's horse and the dirt path leading up to the Crooked Lantern. He reaches into his coat with trembling hands, pulls out his foreclosure note, and slaps it onto a rain-barrel.)*

**[TAM HAYES]**

> "The note says midnight. Take the mill, Huntmaster. It's yours. But you leave the people out of this. The one you're looking for—the Unsworn—they fled over the northern ridge hours ago."

*(Krell looks down at the crumpled note, then back to Tam. She doesn't raise her voice. Instead, she leans forward in her saddle with a cold, almost sympathetic smile, her eyes tracking how Tam has firmly planted his boots across the path.)*

**[HUNTMASTER KRELL]**

> "A brave lie, Miller. But you're a terrible card player. You put your body between my hounds and the inn before you even opened your mouth. Guards, search every building. Collect every note. If they don't have the coin, take the property."

*(Tam realizes he needs to buy more time. He reaches into his coat, but not for another note. He draws a worn deck of dueling cards. The crowd gasps.)*

**[TAM HAYES]**

> "I challenge the debt, Huntmaster! Under the Covenant, you cannot refuse a drawn hand."

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[LORE RULE: The Law of Challenge. By the ancient rules of the Covenant, an official representative of a Dominion Seat or recognized House cannot refuse a formal duel if challenged, but the challenged party has the right to set the stakes.]
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## Prologue P4: The Ashford Reckoning

**[HUNTMASTER KRELL]**

> "Fair enough, Miller. The law states I cannot refuse a duel. But if you wish to go ahead with this, I have the right to set the stakes. And to deter anyone else from trying it... we fight to the death. Draw your Essence."

*(Cut to: Inside the Crooked Lantern's cellar. Krell's words carry across the green. The protagonist turns and rushes toward the stairs.)*

**[PROTAGONIST]**

> "He's going to get himself killed for me! Bram, we have to help him. We can't just leave him out there!"

*(Bram catches the protagonist by the arm before they reach the stairs. For a moment he looks as though he might go back himself. Then he pulls them toward a hidden tunnel behind the ale casks.)*

**[BRAM]**

> "I know, Sprout. And Tam knows what he's sacrificing, and why. If you go out there, you won't save him. You'll give Krell exactly what she came for, and his sacrifice will mean nothing. He's buying us time. We honour that by using it. Through the tunnel, now. I dug it the year we came to Ashford. Don't let Tam's hand go to waste!"

*(Cut back to the green. A massive, armoured hound made of shadow tears through Tam's spectral River Hound. The magical feedback shatters Tam's Ward. He collapses into the dirt, clutching his chest as the last of his life force is drained away. Nell screams, dropping to her knees.)*

**[HUNTMASTER KRELL]**

> "The debt is settled. Search every building. Start with the inn. Keep the houses intact; they're worth more standing. If anyone interferes, subdue them. I want the white card, not a heap of ashes."

*(WIDE SHOT FROM A DISTANT RIDGE: Two Ironvault enforcers draw cards in the moonlit green. One summons a controlled line of fire to block villagers from passing, without touching a house. The other binds a resisting citizen in glowing strands, forcing them to their knees. Soldiers search the homes behind them. No roof burns.)*

*(At the tree line, the protagonist and Bram emerge from the secret passage. Corin waits in the shadows, watching the soldiers take control of the green.)*

**[CORIN]**

> "I'm staying, Sprout. My mam's still down there. Nell and Tilly need someone too. We all swore to keep you hidden, and I'm not walking away now. That clerkship Ironvault offered me... maybe I can use it to find out how to make the House answer for this. You get clear. I'll see you in the city."

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[LORE RULE: Corin later returns bound to Ironvault, his mind altered. He seeks the white
Last Seal card and lays traps for the protagonist. How Ironvault changed him remains a
future reveal; his loyalty here is sincere. The soldiers use restraint magic, not arson.]
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## Prologue P5: The Thornwood Road

*(Night, several hours after the escape. Bram and the protagonist have walked deep into the Thornwood, keeping off the road. The trees knit together overhead; moonlight barely reaches the ground. At last Bram stops beside a bracken-covered rise and pulls aside the roots hanging over a low stone door.)*

**[PROTAGONIST]**

"What is this place? I thought we were going to keep moving."

**[BRAM]**

"An old shelter. Built into the hillside; you'd never find it from the path. I made sure of that. We should be safe here for tonight. We won't stay long - just enough time to eat, sleep and get our strength back. Then we're on our way again. There are provisions inside."

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[OBJECTIVE: Enter Bram's hidden shelter and inspect the provisions.]
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*(The door opens on a cramped stone room. Shelves hold sealed water, bread wrapped in waxed cloth, dried meat and a battered cooking pot. Old Ward marks have been cut into the walls. Bram shuts the door behind them and tests the latch. There is no fire, no lantern, and no window for an enemy to watch.)*

*(While the protagonist lays out the food, Bram rests the cooking pot on a flat stone. He passes his fingers over the metal. A low warmth spreads through it, heating the meal without a spark. For an instant, a faint pattern moves across his knuckles and disappears.)*

**[PROTAGONIST]**

"You can do that? You never used magic at the inn."

**[BRAM]**

"A little heat, kept where it belongs. No flame, no smoke, no glow for a tracker to follow. And at the inn I had good reason not to draw attention. Eat before it goes cold."

*(They sit on opposite sides of a small table and begin to eat. The silence only lasts a moment.)*

**[PROTAGONIST]**

"Bram... what happened to Tam? Did you know Krell was coming? Why did you have a tunnel, and this place, ready? What are you hiding from me? What am I? And that white card - what has it done to me?"

*(Bram lowers his food. He lets the questions hang in the dark.)*

**[BRAM]**

"I don't know what happened to Tam after we went below. I won't pretend otherwise. And yes, I prepared a way out. I hoped it would never be needed. As for the rest... you deserve answers, Sprout. You do. But answers won't stop Krell's hounds when they find our trail."

**[PROTAGONIST]**

"Then tell me what I need to know. Just that much."

## Prologue P5: The Thornwood Road (Continued)

**[BRAM]**

"The Herald named you before the whole valley. That makes you a target, and the white card is the reason Ironvault came. It's part of the Last Seal, not an ordinary duelling card. Keep it hidden. Don't try to play it, don't show it to anyone, and don't let anyone take it. The rest of what I know has waited twenty years. It can wait one more night."

*(Bram reaches into his coat and sets three worn deck-boxes on the table.)*

**[BRAM]**

"I wasn't always an innkeeper. There was a time I travelled this kingdom and survived by my deck. I'm not proud of everything I did. The one I lent you for the Lantern Duel was only a start. Now you need a hand you can trust when I'm not there to tell you what to do. Choose one. I'll teach you what matters."

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[OBJECTIVE: Choose your starting class deck - Scrivener, Mercenary, or Unsworn.]

[LORE RULE: Bram's disclosure limits. He admits preparing the tunnel/shelter and that he used to duel. He shares only the immediate danger: the Herald's public declaration, Ironvault's pursuit, and the need to hide the white card. He does not reveal his former master, true identity, exact age, or full history. Bram does not claim to know Tam's ultimate fate from what he personally witnessed.]
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*(Bram notices the protagonist glance toward the white card tucked inside their coat. He shakes his head.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Not that one. These walls carry old Wards, enough to keep a practice hand from signalling beyond the hill. My warning on the green still stands: don't reveal your power to anyone hunting us. We practise with ordinary cards tonight."

```
[OBJECTIVE: Begin Bram's sheltered practice duel.]
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### INTERACTIVE TUTORIAL: BRAM'S NIGHT LESSON

**ROUND 1 - THE HAND AND ESSENCE**

*(The table becomes a practice duelling field. Bram lays out a simple opening hand and gestures to the Essence crystals.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Draw your hand. Watch your Essence. It returns as the turns pass, but spend it carelessly and you'll have nothing when you need to defend yourself. Read your cards before you play them."

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[TUTORIAL: Draw a card; observe Essence refreshing on the next turn; spend Essence to play a card.]
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## Prologue P5: The Thornwood Road (Continued)

**ROUND 2 - CALL A TOTEM**

**[BRAM]**

"A Totem fights on the field for you. Call it where it can protect you, then choose your attack. An enemy can block, and a bad match of elements can turn a small mistake into a hard lesson."

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[TUTORIAL: Summon a Totem; choose an attack; observe blocking, damage and elemental weakness.]
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**ROUND 3 - THE WARD AND THE RITE**

*(Bram turns one of his cards face down. As the player's Totem advances, the hidden card springs into light.)*

**[BRAM]**

"A Ward waits until the right moment and catches a careless opponent. A Rite is different: you cast it when you choose, and its effect comes at once. A good duellist wins with timing, not just force."

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[TUTORIAL: Set a Ward face down; trigger a Ward; cast a Rite and resolve its effect.]
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**ROUND 4 - ASCENSION AND TIERS**

**[BRAM]**

"Cards can grow stronger. Learn which Totems can Ascend, and when the next tier is worth the Essence. A stronger creature played too soon can leave you helpless on the next turn."

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[TUTORIAL: Inspect card tiers; apply a practice upgrade; Ascend an eligible Totem.]
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**ROUND 5 - PUT IT TOGETHER**

*(Bram plays a short, controlled sequence: a Totem attack, a face-down Ward and a counterattack. The protagonist must decide whether to defend, cast a Rite or press the advantage. The duel ends before anyone can be seriously hurt.)*

**[BRAM]**

"Better. Remember what each card is for. Essence keeps you moving. Totems hold the field. Rites change a moment. Wards punish an opening. And power means very little if you don't know when to hold it back."

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[TUTORIAL: Finish the scripted practice duel using the chosen starter deck.]

[LORE RULE: Tutorial design. The Lantern Duel with Corin remains the early introductory encounter. Bram's shelter lesson is a second, more complete tutorial for draw/Essence refresh, Totems, attacks, elemental weakness, blocks, Rites, face-down Wards and Tier/Ascend upgrades. Do not use or reveal the white Last Seal card here. Exact stats, upgrade costs and turn counts are implemented by the battle system, not fixed by this screenplay.]
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*(Bram closes the deck-boxes. The protagonist opens their mouth, but he raises a tired hand.)*

**[PROTAGONIST]**

"And the other things? Who you really are... and where I came from?"

## Prologue P5: The Thornwood Road (Continued)

**[BRAM]**

> "We'll get to your questions. I promise. But not tonight. You've eaten, and now you've learned enough to make it through a fight without me. That's enough for one day. Get some sleep. At first light, we move."

*(The protagonist settles beneath a folded wool blanket. Bram stays awake by the door, watching the darkness between the Ward marks. Outside, the Thornwood is silent.)*

*(The next morning. No fire has been lit and the shelter is left as they found it. Bram unhooks the door and leads the protagonist back through the trees toward Solhaven.)*

**[BRAM]**

> "Stay close. The city is our best chance of finding someone who understands the old Covenant - and of getting lost in a crowd before Ironvault catches up."

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[OBJECTIVE: Leave the shelter and follow Bram through the Thornwood.]
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*(Further down the road, a young man steps out from the treeline. Dask, Krell's tracker, holds a heavy crossbow and is flanked by a snarling hound. He looks terrified but determined.)*

**[DASK]**

> "Stop right there! Krell put a bounty on you both. I stake every card I own on this duel. If I bring you in, she clears my mother's note. If I don't... well, I'm not going back without trying!"

| Encounter | Opponent | Special Rule |
|---|---|---|
| The Bounty Hunter | Dask (19) | Run to Ground: Dask's hound Totem gains +2 Attack for every turn that passes. |

**POST-DUEL CHOICE: DASK'S FATE**

**Option 1: Let him keep his hound.**

*(Dask remembers this mercy. He will warn you off Krell's ambush in Interlude A.)*

**Option 2: Take everything and send him home.**

*(Dask is humiliated. He will lead Krell's ambush against you in Interlude A.)*

*(The protagonist and Bram leave Dask behind and crest the final ridge of the Thornwood. Below them, bathed in the blinding light of Solmaris, lies Solhaven - the Sun's Court. The end of the Prologue.)*